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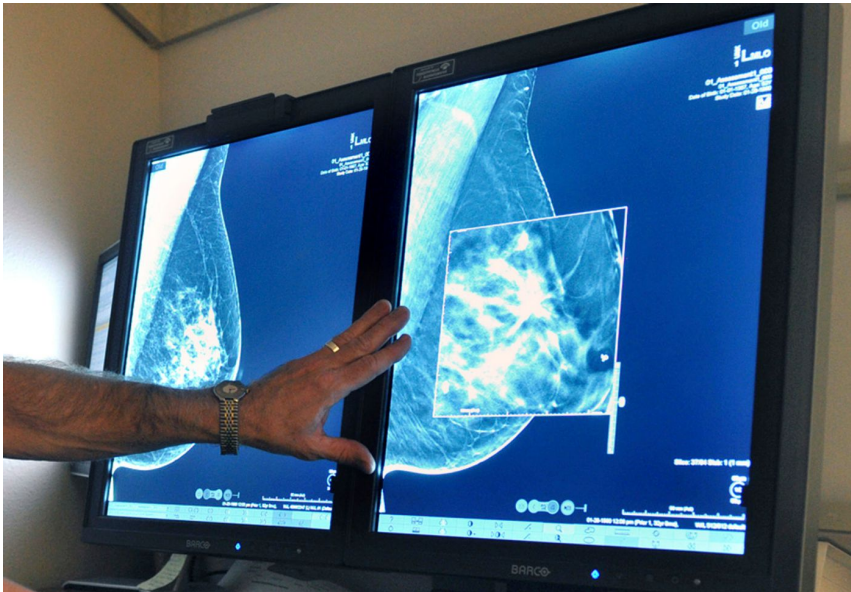
HEALTH

Women Should Be Screened for Breast Cancer 10 Years Earlier, Guidelines Say

New guidance calls for mammograms every other year, while some doctors urge annual checks

By [Brianna Abbott](#) [Follow](#)

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Breast cancer is the second-leading cause of women's cancer death in the U.S. PHOTO: TORIN HALSEY/TIMES RECORD NEWS/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Women as young as 40 should get checked for breast cancer every two years, a government-backed panel of experts recommended, lowering the starting age by a decade but stopping short of the annual screening some doctors recommend.

Women 40 to 74 should get screened every other year, the U.S. Preventive Services Task Force said on Tuesday. It previously recommended that screening every other year start at 50 and that women in their 40s decide when to start screening in consultation with

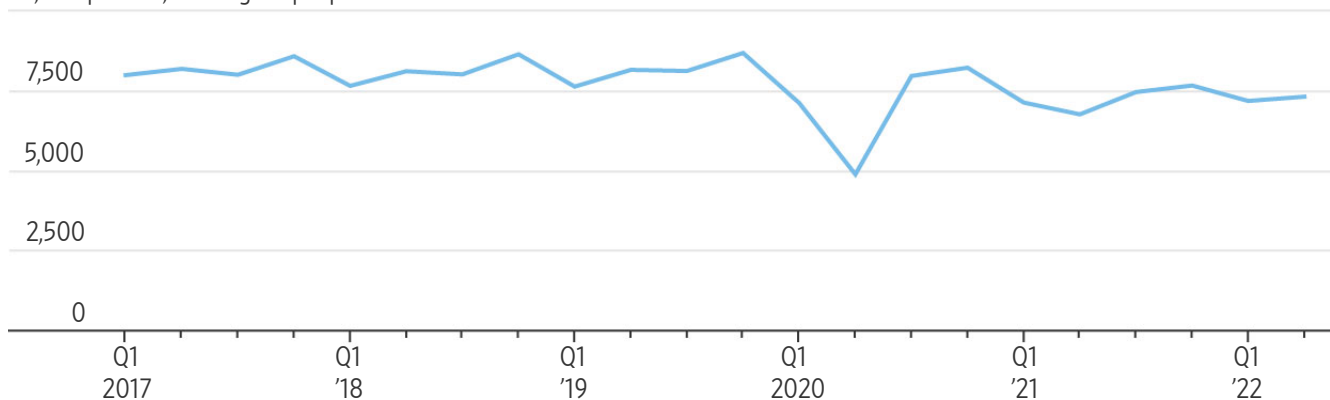
doctors. The task force said its draft guidance for women at average risk could save about 20% more lives than its previous recommendation and could help address the higher rates of breast-cancer deaths for Black women.

“Women in their 40s are developing breast cancer more than ever before,” said John Wong, a member of the task force and chief of the division of clinical decision making at Tufts Medical Center. “Screening women starting at age 40 can reduce their chances of dying from breast cancer.”

Breast cancer trends, U.S. women

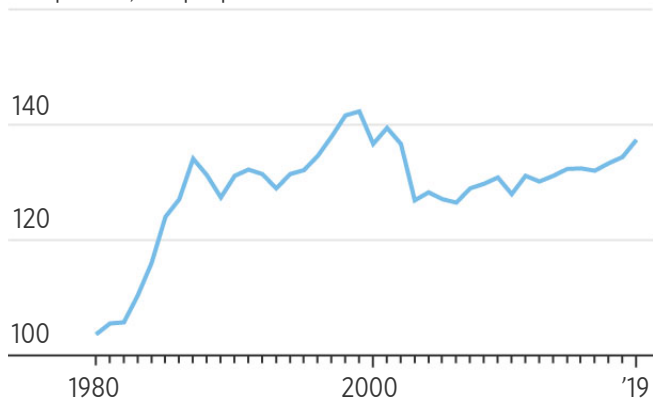
RATES OF ROUTINE BREAST CANCER SCREENING

10,000 per 100,000 eligible people*



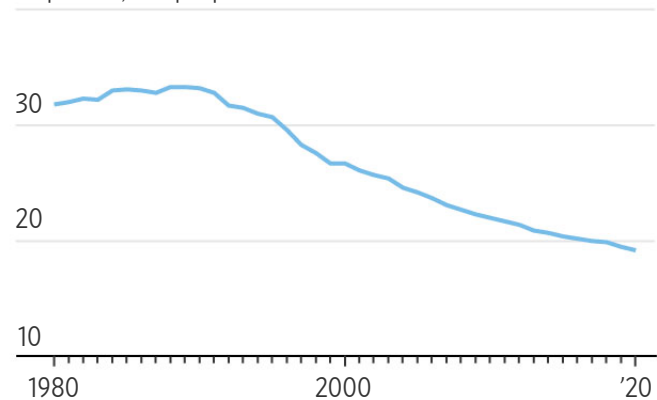
INCIDENCE RATES

160 per 100,000 people



DEATH RATES

40 per 100,000 people



*21-85 years old

Note: Incidence and death rates are age-adjusted

Sources: Trilliant Health (screening rates); American Cancer Society (incidence and death rates)

Elizaveta Galkina/THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

The draft guidance revives a debate about when and how often to screen for breast cancer, as the task force and doctors balance the advantages of frequent screening with potential risks such as false positives. Some breast-cancer doctors and medical groups said mammograms should be annual, and insurers are required to cover them. The American Cancer Society recommends women get annual screens between 45 and 54, after which they can decide to switch to every other year.

The influential task force's new recommendation, which will be open for public comment through June 5, could lead more doctors and patients to embrace mammograms starting at 40. Some doctors and medical organizations wanted the guidance to go further.

"I'm glad that the task force has come around on thinking that women should start screening at 40," said Dr. Debra Monticciolo, division chief of Breast Imaging at Massachusetts General Hospital in Boston. "We really were disappointed that they did not recommend annual screening."

Breast cancer is the No. 2 cause of women's cancer death in the U.S., after lung cancer, according to the American Cancer Society. It is most frequently diagnosed among women between 65 and 74 years old, but incidence has increased for women 40 to 49 years old about 2% a year from 2015 to 2019, the task force said.

Mammograms can help doctors find cancers early, but medical groups have released conflicting guidance on when and how often women should get scanned. The previous guidance from the task force, 16 volunteer preventive-medicine and primary-care experts, was among the most conservative.

Starting mammograms at 40 is a particularly important step for Black women because they often develop aggressive cancers at young ages, the task force said. Black women are 40% more likely to die of breast cancer than white women despite similar screening rates. The task force called for more research on the causes and ways to reduce the disparity.

The task force said there wasn't enough evidence on screening women 75 and older, or to recommend whether women with dense breast tissue should get additional screening with

an ultrasound or MRI. Women over 75 should decide with their doctor whether to continue screening, the group said.

Nearly half of women have dense breasts, which increases the risk for breast cancer and makes mammograms harder to read. The Food and Drug Administration in March said it would require mammography centers to tell women if they have dense breast tissue by later next year.

“If a woman has dense breasts, it’s at least reasonable to consider ultrasound or MRI,” said Dr. William Dahut, chief scientific officer at the American Cancer Society.

Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center in New York offers supplemental screening to women with dense breasts, said Maxine Jochelson, chief of breast-imaging services there. She recommends women get yearly mammograms starting at 40.

“For women who get more aggressive cancers, waiting two years to find them is a recipe for more advanced cancers,” Dr. Jochelson said.

To update the guidance, the task force members analyzed scientific studies and modeling data from the Cancer Intervention and Surveillance Modeling Network to weigh different screening intervals, harms, as well as start and end dates. There wasn’t a clinical trial that compared yearly screening to screening every two years, the task force’s Dr. Wong said.

Using modeling, the task force found that annual screening could convey some benefit but a bigger increase in potential harms. Those harms can include false positives that can lead to anxiety, invasive testing or a loss of faith in the test, doctors said. The scan also carries some risk of radiation exposure or overtreatment of low-risk cancers.

“When you balance lives saved against harms like unnecessary follow-up and treatment, women benefit more when screening is done every other year,” Dr. Wong said.

The draft recommendations don’t apply to women at higher risk because they have had breast cancer before or because of genetic risk factors, a signal on past biopsies or a history of high-dose radiation to their chest at a young age. Those women should also speak to

their doctors about their screening regime, the task force said.

All women should discuss their risk level with a doctor by age 25, said Dr. Natasha Monga, a breast-imaging radiologist at the Ohio State University Comprehensive Cancer Center.

About 70% of women 40 and older had a mammogram within the prior two years, according to 2019 survey data from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The rate was roughly 60% for women between 40 and 49. Screening rates dropped at the height of the Covid-19 pandemic and have rebounded, but many women haven't caught back up on their scans, doctors said.

Many women over 50 don't get screened at all, said Otis Brawley, a cancer epidemiologist at Johns Hopkins University. "We could still save a lot of lives there," Dr. Brawley said.

Susan Ruffini's early-stage breast cancer was caught on a mammogram when she was 48.
PHOTO: SUSAN RUFFINI

Susan Ruffini's early-stage breast cancer was caught on a mammogram in 2006, when she was 48. She got annual mammograms and MRIs after receiving treatment at Memorial Sloan Kettering. In 2019, her mammogram was clean, but her MRI months later found that the cancer had metastasized to her spine. She is getting treated with targeted and hormone therapies, and the cancer hasn't progressed, she said.

"If they can get breast cancer diagnosed early, it gives you more time to be able to treat the breast cancer effectively," said Mrs. Ruffini, who lives on Long Island, N.Y., and volunteers for the North Fork Breast Health Coalition.

Anyone can comment on the draft guidance on the task force website through June 5, after which the task force will release its final recommendation.

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